

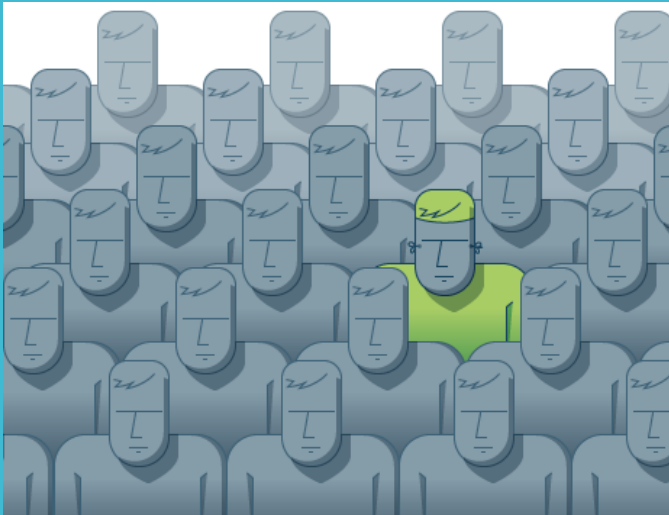
Social Psychology 1



Interpreting the Behaviour of Others & Behaving in the Presence of Others

Lecture 13
Summer 2026
Dr. McPhee

Learning Objectives



Behaving Differently in
the Presence of Others

- By the end of class, students should be able to:
 - ...define **social psychology**.
 - ...understand how we interpret the behaviour of other people through:
 - **Attribution Theory**
 - **Fundamental Attribution Error**
 - **Impression Formation**
 - **Self-Fulfilling Prophecy**
 - ...examine how individuals behave in the presence of others.
 - ...define **conformity**, and describe a famous experiment used to examine it.
 - ...define **groupthink**, and describe the impact of group cognition.
 - ...define the **bystander effect**, **diffusion of responsibility** and **pluralistic ignorance**.
 - ...explain how individuals behave as a result of obedience to authority, and identify the factors that affect the level of obedience.
 - ...describe how social roles and situations influence behaviour as shown through the **Stanford Prison Experiment**.

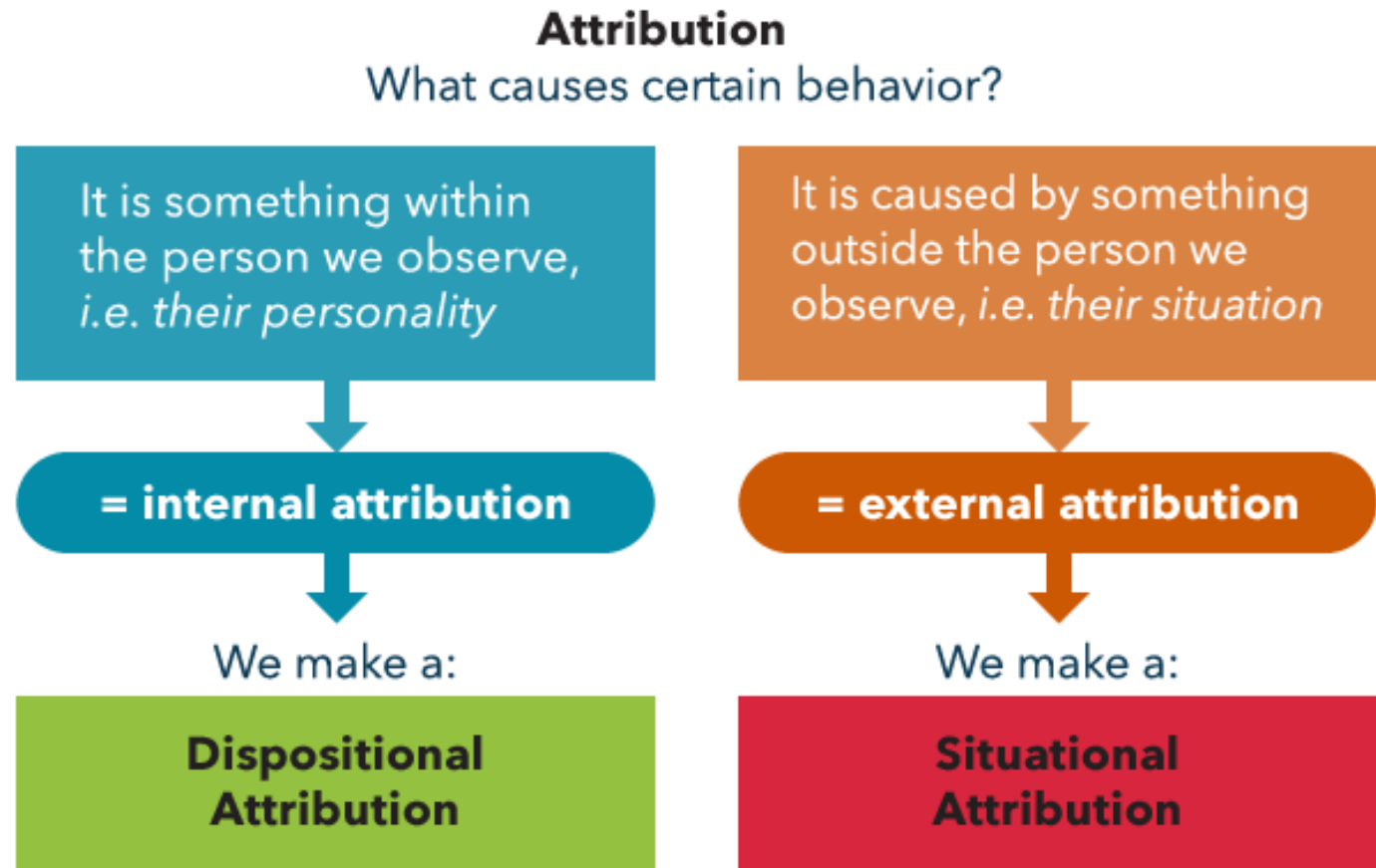
Social Psychology

- **Social Psychology:** the study of the causes and consequences of being social.
- Humans are among the most social species on the planet.
- Humans are considered to be ultrasocial (among other species, such as bees).
- Ultrasocial organisms form large societies, divide labour, and cooperate for mutual benefit.



Interpreting the Behaviour of Others: **Attribution Theory**

- We can attribute others' behaviour to either:
 - **Internal:**
Dispositional, trait-based causes.
 - **External:**
Environmental or situational causes.
- Tend to attribute other's behaviour to internal causes, and our own behaviour to external causes.



A Flowchart Illustrating the Attribution Theory.

Interpreting the Behaviour of Others: **Attribution Theory**

- How do we explain the behaviour of others?
- **Behaviour:** Jane is late for work.
- **Potential Explanations:**
 - Internal/ Dispositional Attribution
 - External/ Situational Attribution

Internal → Dispositional → Jane is irresponsible.



External → Situational → Jane is stuck in traffic.

Interpreting the Behaviour of Others: **Attribution Theory**

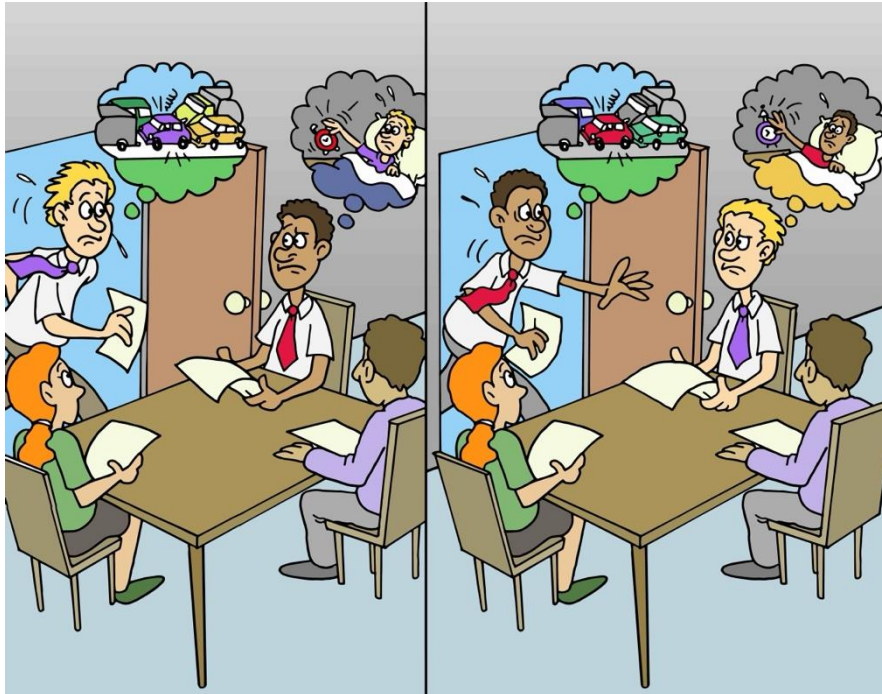


- Kelley's **Covariation Model of Attributions**
- Kelley identified three factors that need consideration when making internal or external attributions:
 1. **Consistency**: Is the person's behaviour similar in particular contexts across time?
 2. **Distinctiveness**: Does the person behave similarly across different situations/contexts?
 3. **Consensus**: Is the behaviour similar or different from other people's behaviour?

Interpreting the Behaviour of Others

- **Actor-Observer Bias**

- Our Behaviour = Situational or External Causes
- Others' Behaviour = Dispositional or Internal Causes



An Animation Illustrating the Actor-Observer Bias.

- **Self-Serving Bias**

- Our Successes = Internal Causes
- Our Failures = External Causes



An Animation Illustrating the Self-Serving Bias.

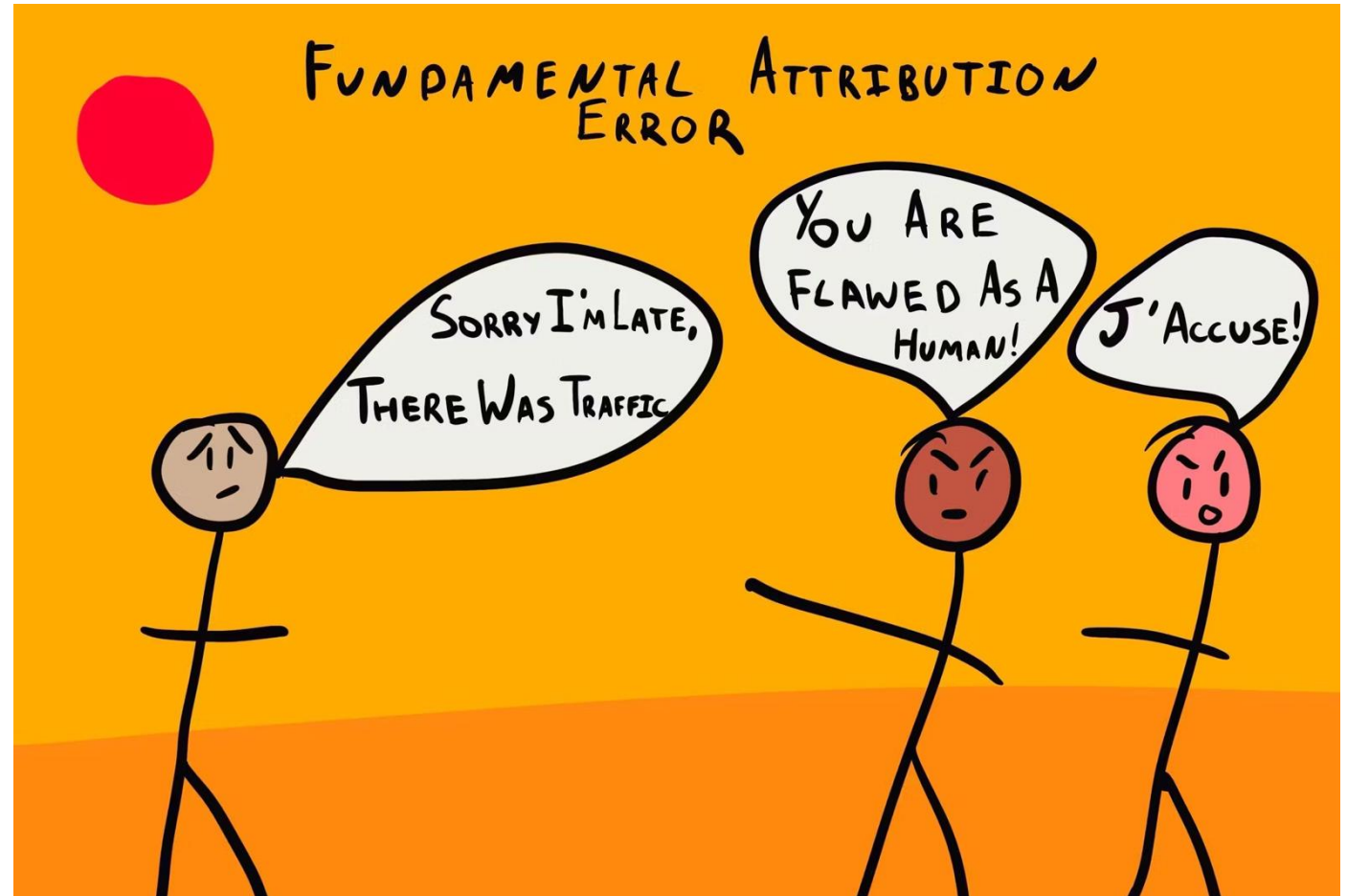
Interpreting the Behaviour of Others: FAE

- **Fundamental Attribution Error**

- Attribute behaviour of others to internal/dispositional causes rather than to external/environmental causes.

- **False Consensus Effect**

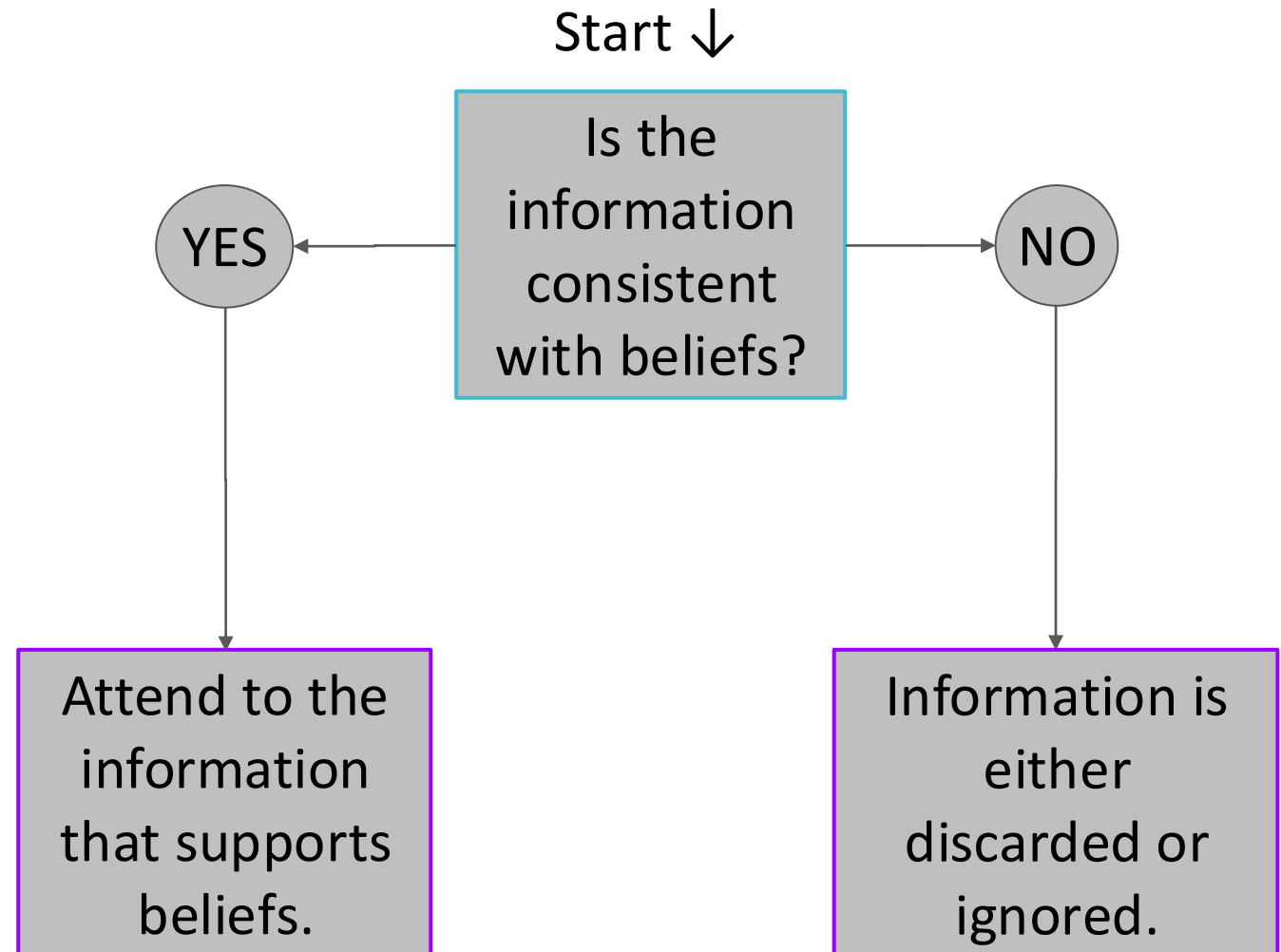
- Thinking “everyone” agrees when they likely do not agree with us.



An Animation Illustrating the Fundamental Attribution Error.

Interpreting the Behaviour of Others: Impression Formation

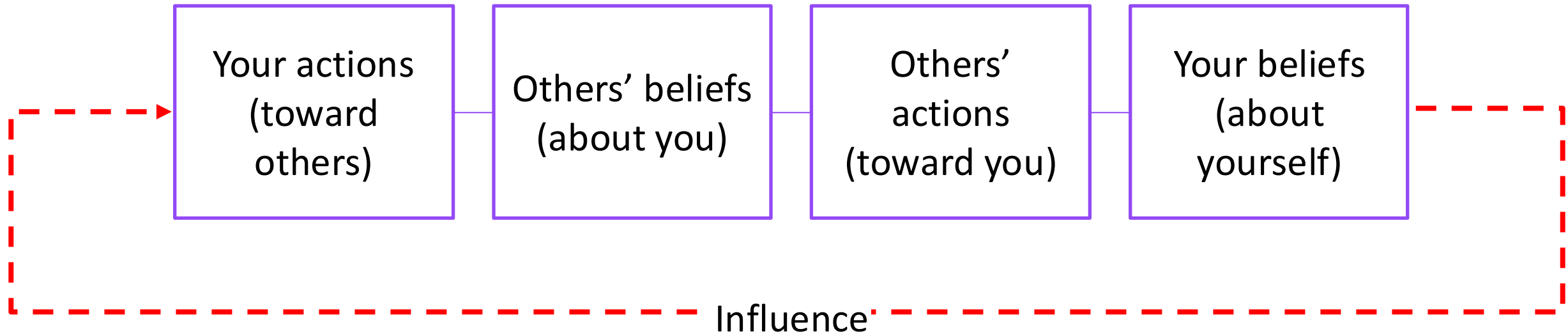
- **Impression Formation**: How we create opinions about people.
- **First Impression**: Initial information learned about someone.
 - Made quickly (in seconds to minutes) and is enduring.
 - **Primacy Effect**.
- **Confirmation Bias**: Occurs when we are more likely to attend to and process information that is consistent with our initial impression.



A Flowchart Depicting the Confirmation Bias

Interpreting the Behaviour of Others: **Self-Fulfilling Prophecy**

•••• Impact •••• •••• Cause •••• •••• Reinforce ••••



A Flowchart Depicting the Self-Fulfilling Prophecy

Behaving in the Presence of Others



YouTube Link: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RVyQo4zkiDs>

Social Norms



Solomon Asch

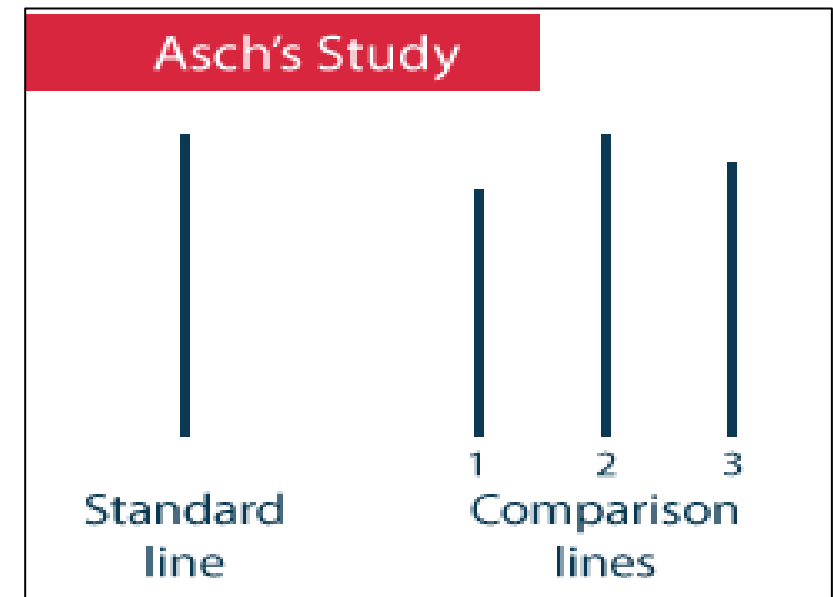
- **Social Norms**: Prescribed behaviours that vary across context, culture, and time.
- **Social Influence**: Our thoughts and behaviours are affected by the behaviour of others.
- The **normative influence** often causes us to **conform** to the behaviour of others.
 - Simply doing what someone else is doing because (s)he/they is/are doing it.
- A famous example of this is **Asch's Conformity Study**.
 - Solomon Asch studied **conformity** in the 1950s.

Asch's Conformity Experiment

- Participants completed a simple perception task:
 - They were asked to compare one standard line and 3 comparison lines.
 - Confederates were present when the comparisons were made (3 or more people).
 - Subjects were asked to report which comparison line was the same length as the standard line.
- Findings:
 - 75% conformed to an obviously incorrect answer at least once.
- Do these findings still apply?



Picture of Asch's Conformity Study



Stimuli That Participants Saw to Determine Conformity

The Impact of Conformity:

Groupthink



The Challenger Space Shuttle Explosion



Pearl Harbor

- **Groupthink**: Faulty decision-making that occurs when a high degree of conformity and group cohesion are highly valued (to the exclusion of opposing information and ideas).
- How Groupthink Works:
 - Overestimating the Group
 - Close-Mindedness
 - Pressure for Uniformity
- Historical Examples:
 - Challenger Space Shuttle
 - Pearl Harbor

Group Cognition

- Groups have their own risks to decision making.



An Example of
Groupthink

Groupthink

Groups can sometimes reach consensus too easily.

Common Knowledge Effect

Group discussions sometimes revolve around information that everyone shares.

Group Polarization

Groups can sometimes make decisions that are more extreme than any member would have made alone.

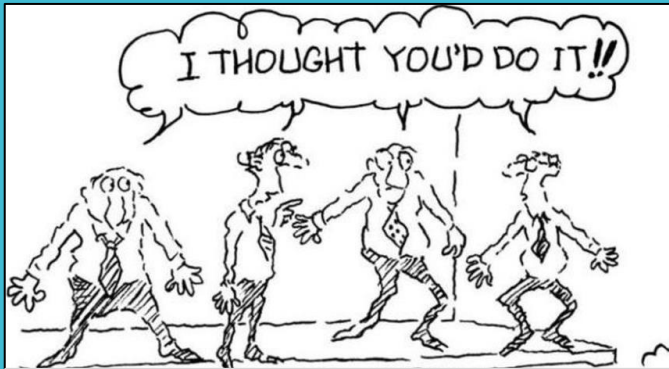
Diffusion of Responsibility

Individuals feel diminished responsibility for their actions when surrounded by others acting the same way.

The Bystander Effect: Thinking Someone Else Will Help



The Bystander Effect



Diffusion of Responsibility

- **Bystander Effect**

- Helping is negatively correlated with number of witnesses.

- **Diffusion of Responsibility**

- Responsibility is spread over all those who are present, and thus no one is held accountable.

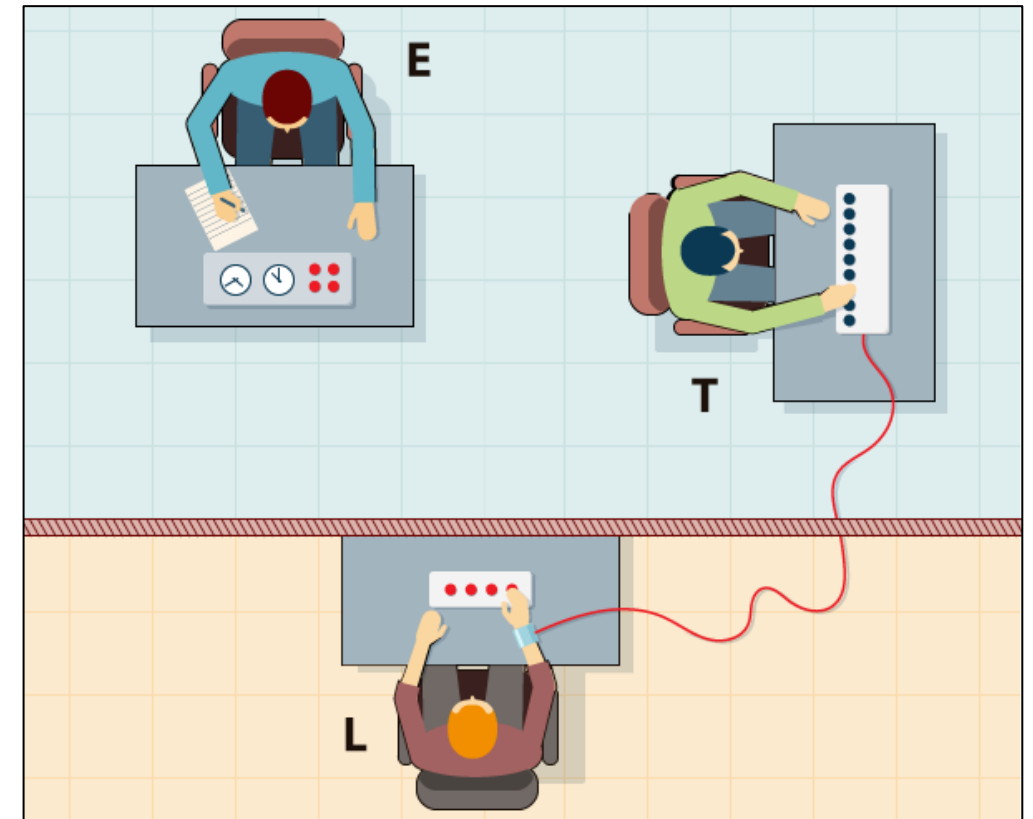
- **Pluralistic Ignorance**

Helping Behaviour is Affected by Three Overarching Themes:

- 1) The Level of Danger Present
- 2) Whether the Perpetrator was Present or Absent
- 3) The Type of Help Required

Obedience to Authority

- Stanley Milgram studied **obedience to authority** in the 1960s.
 - In response to the atrocities of the Holocaust.
- Will “normal” people harm others at the request of an authority figure?
- The Milgram Experiment:
 - Participants recruited for “study of memory”.
 - Shock generator: 30 toggle switches.
 - 15-volt increments.
 - Participant was the teacher.
 - Confederate was the learner.
 - Scripted responses for the confederate.



Set-Up of Milgram's Experiment

E = Experimenter

T = Teacher/Participant

L = Learner/Confederate

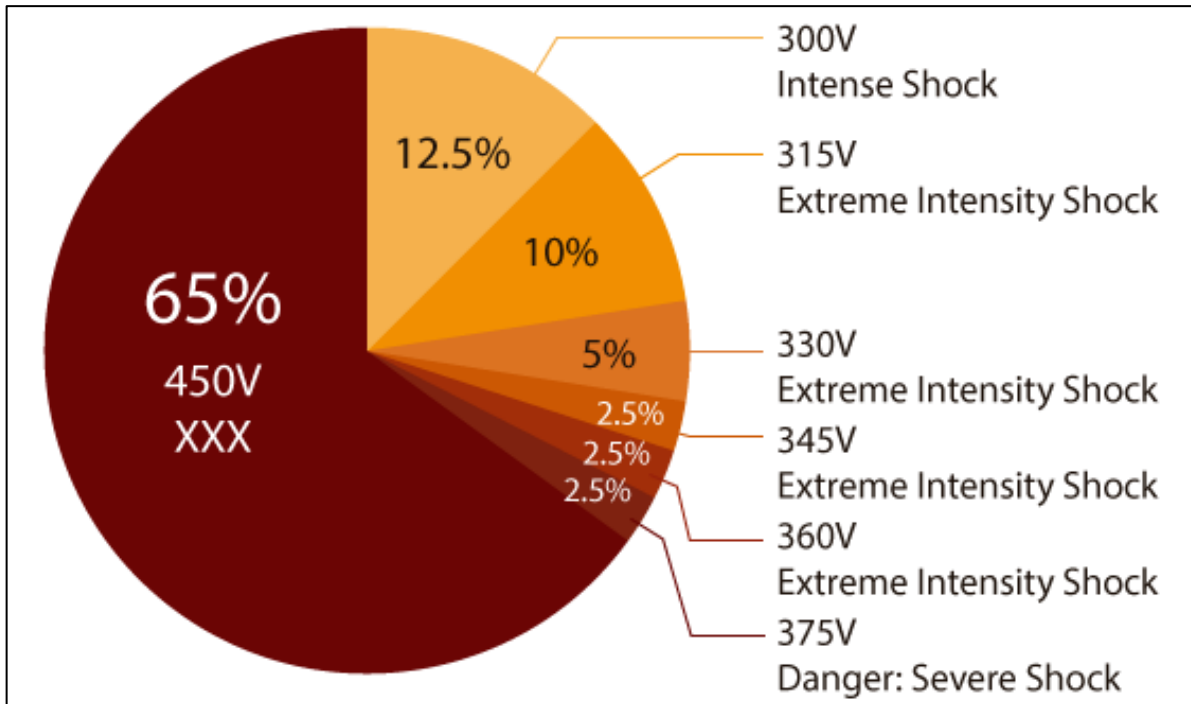
Obedience to Authority



YouTube Link: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jbKlkfk-wtc&t=1s>

Obedience to Authority

- What were the findings?



Most participants continued to shock the learner until the highest voltage in obedience to an authority figure.

- Replication Studies:

- Varied Location
- Distance Between Teacher and Learner

- But what impacts did this experiment have on the participants?

- Psychological Distress/ Depression
- Altered Self-Image
- Disturbed Sleep
- Traumatized Participants

Social Roles and the Power of the Situation



Social Roles and the Power of the Situation



Zimbardo's Stanford
Prison Experiment

- Philip Zimbardo examined the power of situations and social roles in the **Stanford Prison Experiment** in the 1970s.
 - Young men were recruited to participate in Zimbardo's Stanford Prison Experiment.
 - All participants were psychologically healthy at the time of recruitment.
 - Participants were randomly assigned to be a prisoner or guard.
- On the second day of the experiment, feelings of powerlessness, dehumanization and depersonalization began to escalate.
- Simulation of prison experiment was originally scheduled for 14 days but ended early after 6 days due to the horrific circumstances.
- Illustrates the power of the situation and social roles on affecting people's behaviour.
- Also illustrates unethical scientific practices.

Ethical Considerations for Research

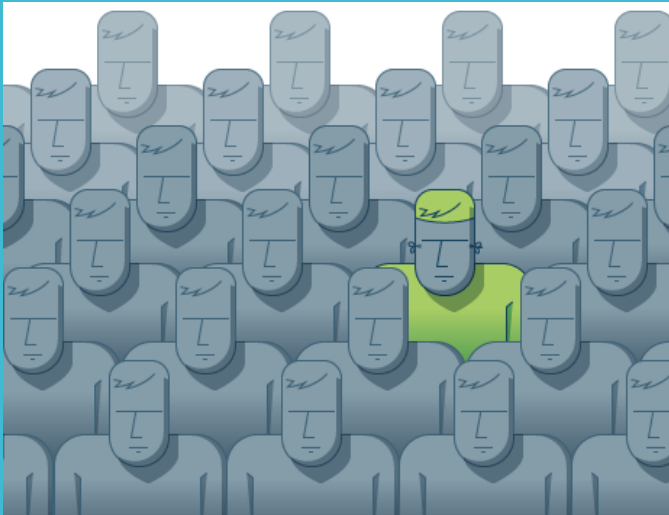
Belmont Report identified basic ethical principles and guidelines for research with human participants.

1. Respect for Persons & Informed Consent.
2. Beneficence. Do no harm.
3. Justice. Subjects should not be exploited.



YouTube Link: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zZ3l1jgmYrY>

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